Still Passing the Buck: Macroeconomic and Fiscal Performance of Argentine Administrations, 1853–2025

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Abstract

We rank all 41 Argentine national administrations that governed between 1853 and 2025 with the two indices proposed by della Paolera, Irigoin, and Bózzoli (2003) — the Classical Macroeconomic Pressure Index (CMPI) and the Fiscal Pressure Index (FPI) — and their combined Overall Index, scoring each government by the macroeconomic and fiscal improvement it delivered over the situation it inherited. A single 173-year scoring frame places every administration, from the mid-nineteenth-century Confederation to the 2024–25 stabilization, on a common scale. Extending the original 1853–1999 analysis through 2025 requires confronting documented distortions in modern Argentine statistics: we catalogue twenty-three manipulation, measurement and accounting practices, correct the affected series from independent and reproducible sources, and retain paper-comparable and sensitivity variants for reconstructed or judgment-sensitive corrections. The 2025 fiscal primary-result operands come from the official annual SPN base-caja dataset. On the restricted 1853–1999 pool the replication of the original rankings is almost exact (Spearman $\rho = 0.996$ for the FPI, 0.953 for the CMPI). In the unified ranking Menem (1990–95) leads the CMPI and the Overall Index, while Obligado (1854–56) leads the FPI. Consolidating the central bank's quasi-fiscal debt into the public debt stock and valuing output at the free-market exchange rate during exchange-control years materially reorders the modern fiscal ranking. Holding the interest dimension at its last functioning-market quotation through the 2002–05 payments default moves the two administrations that straddle that crisis by five and two Overall places (Table 10); the stacked interest restorations also move the 2008–11 term by two. The long-run results are consistent with the original *passing-the-buck* thesis: administrations bought macroeconomic calm with debt — on the Treasury's books or hidden in the central bank — and passed the bill to their successors.

Keywords: Argentina; economic history; macroeconomic performance; fiscal policy; inflation; public debt; statistical integrity; statistical manipulation.

JEL classification: C43; E31; E62; H63; N16; O54.

1 Introduction

How to read the indices. The CMPI and FPI measure *improvement* relative to the situation inherited from the previous administration — not absolute levels. Component scores are percentiles of annual innovations pooled over the 173-year frame: a score of 0.90 means the administration's average annual improvement

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sat in the top 10 percent of all improvements recorded since 1853. Rank 1 is best. See Section 3 for the formulas and three structural caveats, Section 7 for robustness, and the Glossary (Appendix E) for terminology.

How well did each Argentine government manage the economy it inherited? The question dominates Argentine public debate, yet it is usually argued with absolute outcomes — inflation under one president against inflation under another — which conflates what a government did with what it received. della Paolera, Irigoin, and Bózzoli (2003) proposed a comparative answer: score each administration by the *improvement* it delivered over the macroeconomic and fiscal situation bequeathed by its predecessor, and rank all administrations on a common percentile scale. Their Classical Macroeconomic Pressure Index (CMPI) aggregates inflation, devaluation, the hard-currency interest rate, and per-capita growth; their Fiscal Pressure Index (FPI) adds the management of the intertemporal budget constraint; the average of the two is an Overall Index. Applied to 33 administrations over 1853–1999, the framework produced the central finding the authors summarized in their title: Argentine governments repeatedly bought contemporaneous macroeconomic calm with fiscal pressure that they passed to their successors.

This paper extends the complete two-index framework to the full 1853–2025 span — 41 administrations and a common 173-year scoring frame — placing the original 33 historical terms and the eight administrations of 2000–2025 on a single 173-year percentile pool — one scoring frame, not one measurement regime (Section 4). The extension is not a mechanical appending of recent data. Between 2007 and 2015 the national statistical institute (INDEC) falsified consumer-price inflation by a factor of roughly three to four and manipulated real growth, episodes that led to the first declaration of censure in the history of the International Monetary Fund and to the criminal conviction of Commerce Secretary Guillermo Moreno (International Monetary Fund 2013; Cavallo 2013; Coremberg 2017). Exchange controls in 2012–15 and 2019–25 pinned the official exchange rate far below the free-market rate. Successive governments accumulated remunerated central-bank liabilities — a quasi-fiscal debt exceeding ten percent of GDP at its peaks — that appears in no Treasury debt statistic. Any ranking that ingests official series uncritically reproduces these distortions. A second, subtler problem is internal to the methodology: annual-average exchange rates produce wrong-signed devaluation innovations around mid-year devaluations, an artefact that affects the historical sample as well as the modern one.

Our contributions are four. First, we construct corrected 1853–2025 series for the nine variables behind the two indices, documenting every known statistical manipulation and accounting practice that materially affects them — a twenty-three-entry catalogue (Section 4, Appendix B) stating the direction of each bias and its treatment. Corrections enter the corrected baseline when the evidence is independently sourced and the mapping to an index component is documented; paper-comparable official columns and sensitivity variants are retained where reconstruction or judgment could affect the magnitude, reported whichever administration they favour. Second, we resolve the annual-average devaluation artefact by using December-quotation exchange-rate series for the entire sample. Third, we extend the FPI with two corrections to the modern debt-stock components: a free-market revaluation of GDP during exchange-control years, and the consolidation of the central bank's remunerated liabilities into the public debt stock. Fourth, we validate the implementation by replicating the original published rankings on the restricted 1853–1999 pool, obtaining Spearman rank correlations of 0.996 (FPI) and 0.953 (CMPI) against the original Table 3.4.

The headline results place Menem (1990–95) first on the CMPI and the Overall Index, with the 2024–25 stabilization and Obligado's 1854–56 reforms close behind, and crisis terms at the bottom — consistent with the original finding that durable hard-currency and convertible stabilizations score highest. The fiscal corrections are decisive for the modern ranking: once the central bank's hidden debt is consolidated and the exchange-control distortion removed, the 2012–15 and 2020–23 terms occupy the bottom two places on the FPI. The 2012–15 term finishes last mainly because of the exchange gap rather than a comparable BCRA build-up; 2020–23 sits next to it with a quasi-fiscal stock that averaged eleven percent of GDP. The 2024–25 consolidation registers as a sharp reduction in fiscal pressure rather than the spurious increase shown by the raw Treasury series. The long-run picture is consistent with the *passing-the-buck* dynamic over 173 years.

The paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 situates the contribution in the literature. Section 3 presents the methodology. Section 4 describes the data and the corrections. Section 5 reports the rankings. Section 6 validates the implementation against the original study. Section 7 reports robustness exercises. Sections 8–10 discuss interpretation, limitations, and conclusions. A complete replication package accompanies the paper (Appendix A).

2 Related literature

The paper extends della Paolera, Irigoin, and Bózzoli (2003), chapter 3 of *A New Economic History of Argentina* (della Paolera and Taylor 2003), which built the CMPI and FPI for 1853–1999. The long-run quantitative history of Argentine money and finance on which that chapter rests includes della Paolera and Taylor (2001) on the currency-board era, della Paolera (1994) and Cortés Conde (1989) on nineteenth-century monetary and fiscal experiments, Irigoin (2000) and Amaral (1988) on the early inflationary-finance period, and the long statistical series compiled by Ferreres (2010). General economic histories of the period include Gerchunoff and Llach (1998) and Rapoport (2000).

The measurement problems of modern Argentine statistics have their own literature. Cavallo (2013) documents the 2007–2015 INDEC consumer-price intervention using online prices; Cavallo and Rigobon (2016) generalize the methodology; Coremberg (2017) quantifies the parallel volume manipulation of real output growth; the IMF's declaration of censure (International Monetary Fund 2013) is the institutional landmark. Our contribution to this strand is practical: a documented, reproducible mapping from each known distortion to its effect on a long-run performance ranking — including the quasi-fiscal liabilities and exchange-control wedges that standard debt and exchange-rate series omit.

The theoretical background of the indices — seigniorage and the inflation tax, the intertemporal budget constraint, and currency-crisis contagion — is the classical one (Sargent 1986; de Fiore 2000; Ennis 2007; Eichengreen, Rose, and Wyplosz 1996).

Two further strands frame the interpretation. The fiscal-dominance tradition descending from Sargent and Wallace (1981) supplies the mechanism behind the *passing-the-buck* finding: when the fiscal authority does not internalize the intertemporal budget constraint, the monetary authority eventually finances the gap, and inflation becomes a fiscal phenomenon. The comparative project of Kehoe and Nicolini (2021) applies exactly this lens to eleven Latin American countries; its Argentina chapter (Buera and Nicolini 2021) reads six decades of inflation, default, and stabilization as the monetary consequence of persistent fiscal imbalance — the regional pattern of which Argentina is the extreme case, and the same dynamic the FPI traces administration by administration. On the political-economy side, Spiller and Tommasi (2007) document why the dynamic persists: Argentine institutions give policymakers unusually short horizons and weak technologies for enforcing intertemporal agreements, so costs shifted past one's own term are heavily discounted. Finally, the treatment of central-bank operations as fiscal policy in disguise follows the public-finance tradition of Mackenzie and Stella (1996); the modern Argentine remunerated-liability stock that Section 4 consolidates is documented in the IMF's program reports (International Monetary Fund 2022).

3 Methodology

3.1 The Classical Macroeconomic Pressure Index

The CMPI aggregates four classical variables: **inflation**, linked to the government's high-powered-money policy and seigniorage; **devaluation**, the willingness to defend the external value of the currency; the **real interest rate on hard currency**, a proxy for country risk and external credit tightness; and **per-capita growth**, the administration's influence on the pace of real activity.

For each variable and year we compute the **innovation**: the value in that year minus the value in the *last year of the previous administration* — the inherited, or "legacy," condition. Each annual innovation is converted to a percentile rank across all O years in the pool using the original Appendix A formula $R = (O - o)/O$, where o is the innovation's position in the ranking (best = 1): the best innovation in the pool scores $(O - 1)/O \approx 0.994$ and the worst scores 0. An administration's CMPI is the average of its four percentile scores over its term; higher is better. Inflation and devaluation enter as continuously compounded rates $\ln(1+x)$, which prevents extreme episodes from dominating the index.

There is one historical exception. The source has no primary-result/revenues or primary-result/debt-service ratios for 1861–63. We fill those six raw ratios by arithmetic interpolation between the observed 1860 and 1864 endpoints so every FPI component is scored over the same 173-year pool. Geometric interpolation is undefined because Result/Revenue changes sign. Section 4 and Appendix D state the formula and its evidentiary limitation.

To be concrete: a year in which inflation fell from an inherited 40 percent to 10 percent produces an innovation of roughly -0.36 log-points. This scores near the top of the percentile distribution and contributes to a high CMPI *regardless of whether 10 percent is "low" in absolute terms.* The comparative design is what makes the index informative about governance rather than about inherited luck.

3.2 The Fiscal Pressure Index

The CMPI captures contemporaneous performance, but for a peripheral economy with recurrent debt crises this is insufficient. The FPI ranks administrations by their management of the intertemporal budget constraint, built on the first-order difference equation for the debt ratio that drives the original study's transversality condition:

$$\frac{B_t}{Y_t} = \frac{1 + r_t}{1 + g_t} \frac{B_{t-1}}{Y_{t-1}} + \frac{DEF_t}{Y_t},$$

where B/Y is the debt-to-GDP ratio, r the real interest rate, g the growth rate, and DEF the primary deficit. The FPI aggregates five indicators, each scored exactly like the CMPI as an innovation percentile: **debt/GDP** (the burden relative to activity), **debt/exports** (the burden relative to repayment capacity), **primary result/revenues** (net fiscal management, discounting inherited debt service), **primary result/debt service** (resources available to service the debt), and $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$ (the amplifying factor on the debt ratio; values above one mean the debt ratio grows automatically even with a balanced primary budget). High indebtedness or an unbalanced budget is a "hot potato" passed to successors; the opposite is a positive externality future governments inherit.

Following the original Table 3.4, the **Overall Index** ranks administrations by the simple average of their CMPI and FPI scores. The exact formulas behind every step — innovations, percentile assignment, aggregation, and the two debt-stock corrections — are collected in Appendix D.

3.3 Fidelity to the original design

Design element	Original study	This extension
Unit of analysis	Argentine national administrations through 1999	Same intervals through 1999; modified majority-of-year rule for the extension through 2025
Inherited baseline	Each year scored against the predecessor's last observation	Same rule, recomputed after the administration-year classifier is applied
Annual scoring	Innovation percentiles using $R = (O - o)/O$; six 1861–63 fiscal relative indices completed after ranking	Same percentile formula on the 1853–2025 frame; the six missing 1861–63 raw ratios are arithmetically interpolated before ranking so $O = 173$ for every component
CMPI variables	Inflation, devaluation, interest, growth	Same variables; growth is consistently per-capita
FPI variables	Debt/GDP, debt/exports, two primary-result ratios, $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$	Same variables with corrected-baseline and paper-comparable fiscal columns retained
Weights	Equal component weights; Overall = mean(CMPI,FPI)	Same weights; component exclusions reported as robustness checks
Interest seam	Published term averages through 1999	Original averages through 1997; annual EMBIG from 1998, restored to the original's rate-level concept (risk-free leg added back; default window held)
Data corrections	Official historical series mostly used as published	Documented statistical/accounting distortions corrected or classified in Appendix B
Recent-data status	Not applicable	Complete annual observations are used for 2025, but recent national-account values remain subject to source revisions

3.4 How to read the ranking: three structural caveats

The method has three properties that every reader should hold in mind. They are features of the original design, applied uniformly to all 41 administrations — not data corrections, and not fixable without changing what the index measures.

1. **Improvement is not the end state.** The index scores each year against the situation *inherited*, averaged over the term — not the state in which an administration leaves the country. A term that inherits a catastrophe and stabilizes it scores high even if absolute conditions remain poor; a term that inherits calm and ends in crisis scores

low even if its average year was comfortable. Section 8 discusses the clearest modern case.

2. **Term averages favour short corrective shocks.** Stabilizations front-load their best macroeconomic years, so a two-year term can outscore four-to-six-year terms that include later decay. Section 7 re-scores every administration on its first two years only, putting different administration lengths on the same two-year observation window.

3. **Single-year inherited baselines amplify V-shaped shocks.** Because every year of a term is measured against the predecessor's *last* year, a collapse-and-rebound pair inside one term (COVID: −10.3 percent per-capita growth in 2020, +10.2 percent in 2021) is lightly penalized on the way down and fully rewarded on the way back.

3.5 Administration boundaries

The 41 terms follow the original intervals exactly where the two studies overlap (33 terms, 1853–1999), including the rule of assigning each year to whoever ruled the larger part of it. Conventions carried over from the original study: single-year caretaker terms are kept separate when conventionally distinguished (Alsina 1853, Uriburu 1931, Guido 1962–63); military juntas are presented as one term (1976–83); civilian transition periods with rapid turnover are combined.

For 2000–2025, administration-years follow a **modified majority-of-year rule**. A transition year remains with the outgoing-originated policy episode only when all four pre-specified conditions hold: (1) the incoming president would otherwise receive the year; (2) the outgoing Economy Minister remains continuously in office through year-end; (3) the incoming government retains the core stabilization regime in at least **four of five** predefined domains — fiscal, monetary, exchange-rate, banking, and sovereign-debt policy; and (4) the transition year is the program's first complete calendar-year observation, regardless of its results. Constitutional tenure is reported separately. This project-specific rule is applied to every transition before scoring; it classifies policy continuity rather than assigning exclusive causal credit. It is not a standard coding convention, but the intersection of three established practices used elsewhere in the literature:

1. **De facto regime classification.** Exchange-rate classifications distinguish announced legal arrangements from policies actually implemented (Reinhart and Rogoff 2004; Levy Yeyati and Sturzenegger 2005). By analogy—not as a direct precedent—a presidential transfer is a de jure change but need not constitute a de facto economic-regime break when both the Economy Minister and core policy instruments remain unchanged.

2. **Action-based episode dating.** Stabilization, growth-acceleration, fiscal-consolidation, and liberalization studies date episodes from observable announcements, measures, or documented policy actions rather than electoral boundaries (Easterly 1996; Calvo and Végh 1999; Hausmann, Pritchett, and Rodrik 2005; Giavazzi and Tabellini 2005; Devries et al. 2011; Guajardo, Leigh, and Pescatori 2014). This motivates treating a continuing stabilization regime as an economic-policy episode; it does not establish a standard rule for presidential attribution.

3. **Finance-minister continuity.** Fiscal-governance research models a strong finance minister as an agenda setter or delegated veto player, while empirical work associates ministerial characteristics and continuity with deficits and debt (Hallerberg and von Hagen 1999; Jochimsen and Thomasius 2014; Moessinger 2014). Ministerial continuity is an observable institutional marker, not proof that the minister controls every CMPI or FPI outcome.

The sole qualifying transition is 2003. Roberto Lavagna entered office on 27 April 2002; Eduardo Duhalde's constitutional tenure ended and Néstor Kirchner's began on 25 May 2003; Kirchner retained Lavagna through year-end (and until November 2005). The pre-scoring audit records continuity in fiscal, monetary, exchange-rate, and banking policy, but not sovereign-debt policy. Accordingly, 2003 is assigned to the **Duhalde-originated, Kirchner-retained Lavagna policy episode**; this does not imply that Duhalde legally governed the whole year or exclusively caused its outcomes. The 2025 calendar-year observation is complete and enters every headline score. Milei's presidency is still in progress and its constitutional term runs through 10 December 2027, so the 2024–25 administration ranking is interim.

4 Data

4.1 Two data regimes

The series combine two regimes. For **1852–1963** we read the original authors' annual dataset (`data_a_1999.xlsx`): inflation and devaluation as annual log-differences, per-capita growth, and the four fiscal ratios. Interest rates use the published term averages of the original Table 3.1, since the dataset contains no annual interest series; the 1852 baseline is derived from the original Table 3.2. The workbook carries no fiscal observations for 1852, so the four FPI ratios are set to zero in that year. This is a convention, not a measurement, and it has one consequence worth stating: the 1853 Alsina term is a single year scored against it, so its fiscal innovations are the 1853 *levels* rather than changes — a debt ratio of 0.60 and a primary result of -1.21 times revenues read as a deterioration from a debt-free starting point that never existed. Alsina finishes last on the FPI and last overall. The convention reproduces the original study's placement of the term, and we keep it for comparability rather than because the implied baseline is credible.

The workbook also has genuine blanks for primary result/revenues and primary result/debt service in 1861–63. We fill those six raw ratios by arithmetic interpolation between the observed 1860 and 1864 endpoints, so contemporaneous averages, innovations, and percentiles all use the same 173 rows. Geometric interpolation is undefined because Result/Revenue changes sign. This complete-pool convention differs from Appendix A of della Paolera, Irigoin, and Bózzoli (2003) (pp. 78–79 and footnote 33), which ranked the available observations first and interpolated only the resulting relative-index scores. The archived chapter calls that both a "constant growth rate" and a "constant-rate-change" interpolation but supplies no equation or filled values. We disclose the raw-ratio formula in Appendix D. The three filled years remain reconstructed observations, not measurements, and are graded C in the quality flags.

For **2000–2025** debt ratios use total Sector Público Nacional gross debt from the Secretaría de Finanzas (Secretaría de Finanzas, Ministerio de Economía 2025) divided by World Bank GDP and exports; fiscal ratios use the SPN cash-basis ("base caja") primary result from datos.gob.ar SSPM dataset 379 for 2000–2025 (Subsecretaría de Programación Macroeconómica 2026). The generated record retains current revenue, primary result, financial result, and net interest before deriving both ratios. For **1964–2025** macro variables (inflation, growth, devaluation, interest) we use annual values from the World Bank World Development Indicators (World Bank 2025), INDEC price and national-accounts series, and the EMBIG Argentina country-risk spread from 1998 (Banco Central de Reserva del Perú 2025). Free-market exchange-rate quotations for the exchange-control years come from public APIs (ArgentinaDatos 2025) and the December-quotation devaluation series for 1960–1999 from Ruíz (1990) and the original dataset.

World Bank 2025 national accounts are in the raw snapshot and in the headline series: per-capita growth is 4.014 percent (`NY.GDP.PCAP.KD.ZG`); Debt/GDP and Debt/Exports use World Bank current-US$ GDP (≈ US$683~bn) and exports of goods, services and primary income (≈ US$112~bn). Complete annual observations are used for 2025, but recent national-account values remain subject to source revisions. The debt numerator is the final year-end total Sector Público Nacional gross-debt workbook, and the 2025 fiscal primary-result ratios use the official annual Secretaría de Hacienda SPN cash-basis ("base caja") dataset.

4.2 What the inflation variable measures

Because the inflation dimension carries the largest weight in the CMPI's interpretation, its composition is worth stating exactly. For **1852–1963** it is the original workbook's annual log-difference series. For **1964–2025** it is the simple average of two legs: a consumer-price leg and a wholesale-price leg (INDEC IPIM, `FP.WPI.TOTL`, available every year but 2001, when the consumer leg stands alone). The consumer leg is itself spliced — the World Bank consumer-price *level* for Argentina begins only in 2016, so the leg is the GDP deflator (`NY.GDP.DEFL.KD.ZG`) for 1964–2016 and the INDEC IPC from 2017. The 2007–2015 values of the blend are replaced wholesale by the alternative-index average described above.

The historical leg is coarser still. In the original workbook the nineteenth-century inflation and devaluation series are piecewise constant within administrations rather than genuinely annual — inflation reads 3.19 percent for each of 1854–56 and 0.53 for each of 1857–59 — and over 1853–59 the two series are numerically identical, the price proxy being the currency's external depreciation. They separate from 1860 (1.68 against 2.08). Inflation is therefore the CMPI's coarsest dimension in the early sample, which is why Section 7 reports what happens to Obligado's rank when it is dropped.

Two further consequences follow for the modern leg, and neither is cosmetic. First, for most of the modern period "inflation" is half a wholesale-price index and, before 2017, half an output deflator rather than a consumer-price index. Second, both legs are **annual averages**, so the variable is an average-over-average rate, while the devaluation dimension is measured December-to-December. The two dimensions therefore date the same event differently: a disinflation that happens within a year shows up immediately in the December devaluation series but only with a year's lag in the averaged inflation series.

The 2024–25 term is where this bites hardest. On the annual-average convention, inflation reads 137.4 percent in 2023 and 217.6 in 2024, so the 2024 innovation against the inherited 2023 base is +0.29 log points — a *deterioration*. Measured December-to-December the same two years read 211.2 and 117.7 percent, an innovation of −0.36 — one of the sharpest disinflations in the sample. The averaged convention costs the term its inflation score in the first of its two years and is the main reason its inflation component is 0.514, close to the pool median, while its devaluation component is 0.928. We retain the annual-average convention rather than promoting the December series because the December-to-December blend can only be built back to 1944 and its wholesale leg is unavailable throughout, so substituting it would split the 173-year pool at a second seam and change the variable's definition for the historical regime, where the original workbook supplies annual data only. The direction of the resulting bias is stated in the Limitations.

Figure 1 maps data reliability by year and variable; the full lineage of every series is documented in the replication package.

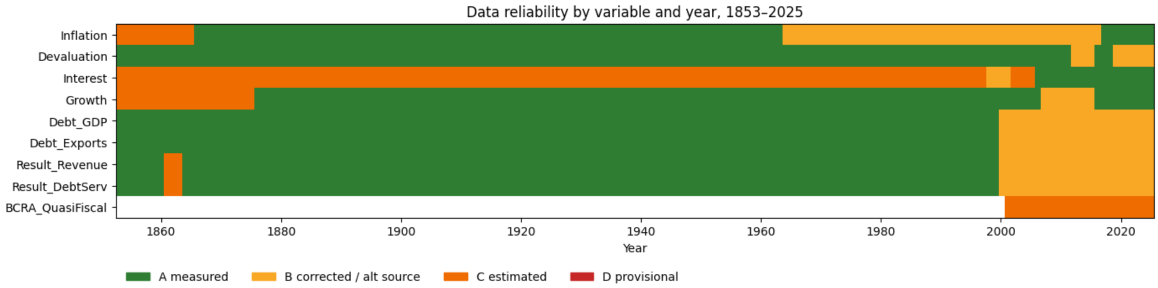

Figure 1: Data reliability by year and variable across the nine index inputs. Letters grade source quality; the catalogue in Appendix B documents every flagged episode.

4.3 Statistical integrity: known statistical manipulations, measurement distortions, and accounting practices

An internally comparable assessment of Argentine administrations must confront a documented fact: several governments manipulated official statistics — the 2007–2015 INDEC consumer-price index, criminally adjudicated — or used fiscal and monetary accounting that flatters the headline numbers while shifting costs across time or off the books. Appendix B catalogues every such practice known to materially affect the nine variables behind the CMPI and FPI — twenty-three entries spanning 1931–2025 — stating for each the direction of the bias and its treatment here.

The treatment discipline is explicit. **Corrected / corrected-baseline** practices are fixed in the headline only when each row resolves to a retained official artifact, exact URL, source locator, extraction formula, uncertainty statement, and SHA-256. Fiscal percentages are generated from exact official peso operands and the same dataset-379 revenue or World Bank GDP denominators used by the scoring pipeline. Official or paper-comparable series remain as audit columns and official-versus-corrected charts expose the size of each correction. **Sensitivity-only** practices remain too judgment-dependent for the headline, so they enter as documented memo columns and re-ranked variants, reported whichever administration they favour. **Documented** practices are outside the nine index variables or not confidently quantifiable, and are flagged for the reader. No adjustment relies on the unsupported assertion of any government, including the current one.

Coverage asymmetry across eras. The corrections above are symmetric in *direction* — they penalise whichever administration understated a burden and credit whichever consolidated it — but their *coverage* is not symmetric across eras. The 2000–2025 series are corrected against independent, reproducible sources, whereas the 1853–1999 series are used as the original authors published them, and several historical distortions (the 1931–59 parallel-exchange premia and the 1980s *Cuenta de Regulación Monetaria* quasi-fiscal deficit) enter only as sensitivity variants rather than the headline, because no single reproducible series reconstructs them. This is a data-availability constraint rather than a modelling choice, but it does mean the cross-era ranking is not fully apples-to-apples: the modern terms are scored on corrected inputs while the historical terms carry whatever distortions their original sources contained. Section 7 reports the 1946–59 premium overlay as a re-ranked exercise; the 1977–90 quasi-fiscal stock remains a documented historical bound rather than a scored variant. Consistent with the other variants there, they do not displace the top of the ranking, and the reader should weigh the residual non-comparability accordingly.

The baseline carries the corrections that can be implemented with reproducible, sourced data:

Consumer prices, 2007–2015. INDEC's manipulation of the CPI — a fake official index — understated inflation roughly three- to four-fold. The episode ended in the IMF censure (International Monetary Fund 2013) and the criminal conviction, upheld on appeal, of Commerce Secretary Guillermo Moreno for abuse of authority over the IPC. The baseline replaces those years with the continuous official Santa Fe IPEC December-to-December chain (Instituto Provincial de Estadística y Censos de Santa Fe 2017). Official CABA and San Luis series are retained as sensitivities where their pinned files overlap (Dirección General de Estadística y Censos de la Ciudad de Buenos Aires 2015; Dirección Provincial de Estadística y Censos de San Luis 2016).

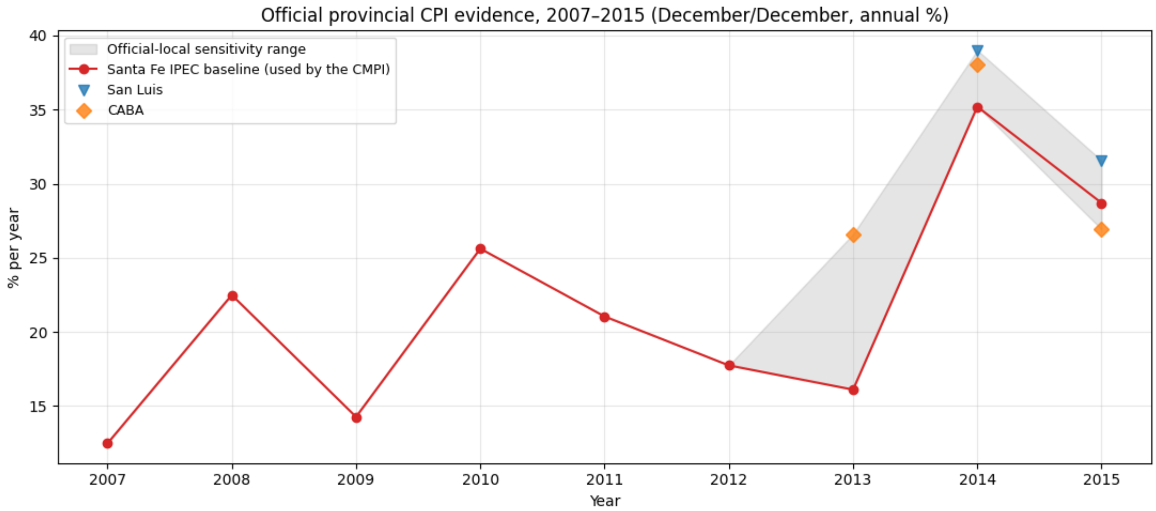

Figure 2: Official provincial CPI evidence, 2007–2015. The baseline uses the continuous Santa Fe IPEC chain; CABA and San Luis observations bound official-local sensitivities where available.

Real output growth, 2007–2015. The same INDEC takeover produced volume manipulation in the base-1993 national accounts (2008 official +6.8 versus revised +4.1 percent; 2009 +0.9 versus −5.9, both on total GDP). The World Bank series used here embed INDEC's 2016 revision, whose cumulative 2008–15 correction matches the independent ARKLEMS reconstruction (Coremberg 2017). Figure 3 compares the vintages.

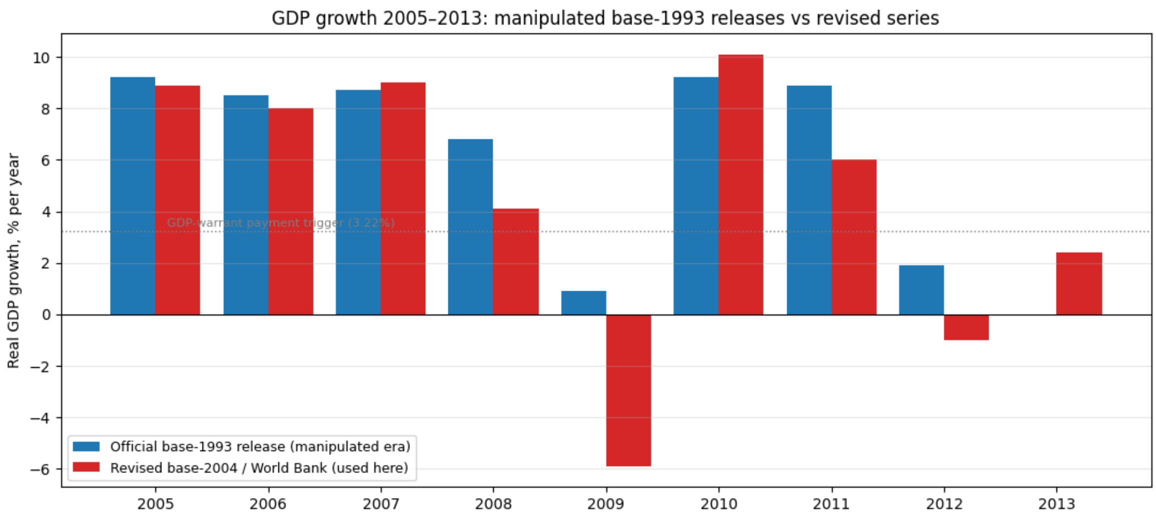

Figure 3: Official base-1993 real growth versus the 2016-revision series, 2005–2015.

Devaluation: December quotations for the full sample. Annual-average exchange rates blend pre- and post-devaluation months, producing wrong-signed innovations around mid-year devaluations. We use December quotations for the entire 1853–2025 span: the original authors' series to 1999 (which embeds the free-market *dólar libre* of Ruíz (1990) for 1960–89), then December BCRA wholesale rates in free years and December free-market (CCL/blue) averages in exchange-control years from 2000. Section 6 shows that this choice reproduces the original published devaluation innovations exactly for the four terms affected by mid-year devaluations.

Exchange-control wedges. During the *cepo* years (2012–15, 2019–25) the official rate was administratively pinned with a free-market premium that reached 100 percent. Measuring the regime by its deeds rather than its words (Levy Yeyati and Sturzenegger 2005), devaluation uses free-market December averages (Figure 4); the fiscal corrections below remove the parallel distortion of the dollar-valued GDP in the debt ratios.

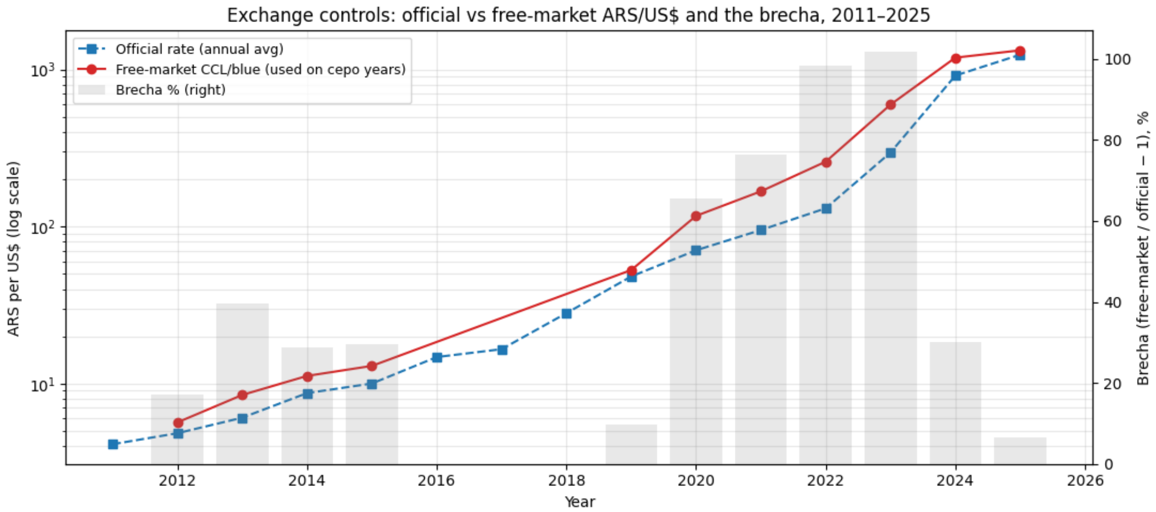

Figure 4: Official versus free-market (CCL/blue) exchange rate during the exchange-control years; the premium ("brecha") reached 100 percent.

4.4 Restoring the interest concept

The original defines its third variable as *"the real interest rate on hard currency ... a proxy for country risk fluctuations and tightness in the credit market"* — a rate **level**, and its own 1852–1997 series is one. The BCRP EMBIG series that extends the dimension from 1998 is a **spread**, which drops the risk-free leg and breaks the level at the seam. Adding the US ten-year real yield back closes it: 1997 reads 9.75 percent and 1998 reads 9.88 percent, against 5.98 for the bare spread — a level jump of +0.13 instead of −3.77 percentage points.

A second restoration is required for the 2002–H1 2005 payments default. In those years the quotation is not a borrowing cost: it prices instruments on which no coupons were being paid, while the sovereign had no market access at all, and the June-2005 exchange then rebuilt the index on the post-haircut bonds. Read as a rate, the window produces innovations 3.5 times larger than anything else in the 173-year pool and sits far outside the historical support (a maximum of 57.9 percent against 17.4 for 1852–1997). The treatment is the one already applied to the pinned official exchange rate under exchange controls — replace a distorted price with a meaningful one — here by holding the last quotation from a functioning market, the 2001 level of 19.07 percent. Innovations inside the window are then zero, which states honestly that no rate was observable. The innovation column contracts from ±0.51 to ±0.15.

Both restorations are curated, ESTIMATE-flagged and reverted end to end in Section 7. Both are symmetric: the 2002–03 term rises because it stops being charged for the market price of debt it was not paying, and the 2004–07 term falls because it stops being credited for that price disappearing. Neither degrades the replication — the restricted-pool correlation against the original Table 3.4 *improves* on the CMPI, from 0.952 to 0.953, and holds on the FPI at 0.996 — and the Overall podium is unchanged. Because the same series builds the FPI's $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$, both restorations move two of the nine components and both indices are re-ranked together throughout.

4.5 Two corrections to the modern debt stock

The FPI's two debt-stock components require corrections that no official series provides.

First, the **exchange-control revaluation**: during cepo years the dollar-valued GDP in the debt/GDP denominator is inflated by the artificially low official rate. The headline keeps the published USD Treasury stock and replaces that official GDP with GDP converted at the free-market (CCL/blue) rate. Central-bank remunerated liabilities are then added unscaled: they are already a peso/GDP ratio, so multiplying them by the gap would treat a Treasury migration of the same stock as new foreign-currency debt. Section 7 retains 50 percent exposure as a conservative lower bound.

Second, the **consolidation of quasi-fiscal debt**: from 2002 the central bank sterilized monetary emission with remunerated liabilities (Lebac/Nobac, then Leliq, then Pases) that repeatedly exceeded ten percent of GDP — economically public debt, but absent from every Treasury statistic. The correction adds the measured year-end stock (BCRA statistical-API series, December observations) to the public debt of 2003–2025. Figure 5 shows the layered debt stock. The associated quasi-fiscal interest flow never enters the Treasury's primary result and is omitted from the scored index (Appendix B, row 12).

Table 1 summarizes both corrections by administration. The corrections are decisive for the modern fiscal ranking (Section 5), and symmetric: they penalize the administrations that accumulated hidden liabilities and credit those that consolidated them, whichever side of the political spectrum either falls on.

Table 2: Exchange-control factor and central-bank quasi-fiscal debt by administration (term means). "Cepo x" is the free-market/official factor applied to the whole published USD Treasury stock. "BCRA % GDP" is the remunerated-liability stock consolidated into public debt, unscaled.

Administration	Years	Debt/GDP off.	Cepo x	BCRA % GDP	Debt/GDP adj.
Duhalde	2002-2003	1.487	1.000	1.712	1.504
N.Kirchner	2004-2007	0.817	1.000	5.404	0.934
C.Kirchner	2008-2011	0.461	1.000	4.270	0.544
C.Kirchner II	2012-2015	0.415	1.397	4.563	0.653
Macri	2016-2019	0.587	1.025	7.217	0.677
Fernandez	2020-2023	0.703	1.857	11.387	1.433
Milei	2024-2025	0.699	1.186	0.028	0.847

The same discipline governs the primary-balance components. The corrected headline removes only measured official FGS property income, booked BCRA transfers, exact 2016–17 and 2024 regularization receipts, and the official 2021 SDR booking (Banco Central de la República Argentina 2015; Administración Federal de Ingresos Públicos and Agencia de Recaudación y Control Aduanero 2024; Oficina de Presupuesto del Congreso 2021). Official

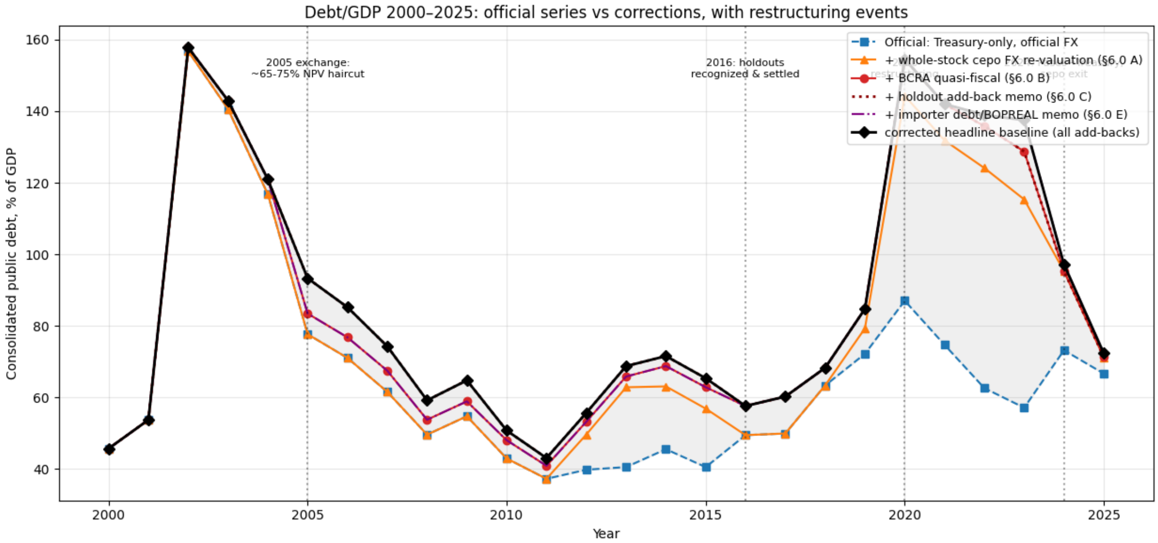

Figure 5: Public debt layers, 2001–2025: official Treasury stock, exchange-control revaluation, and consolidated central-bank remunerated liabilities.

OPC 2024–25 capitalized-interest operands adjust the debt-service ratio (Oficina de Presupuesto del Congreso 2025). Every amount is retained in pesos and linked row-by-row to its source; the generator derives the percentages. Author-estimated models do not enter the paper; mechanisms without reproducible official annual operands are disclosed only as limitations. Figure 6 contrasts the reported and measured structural primary results.

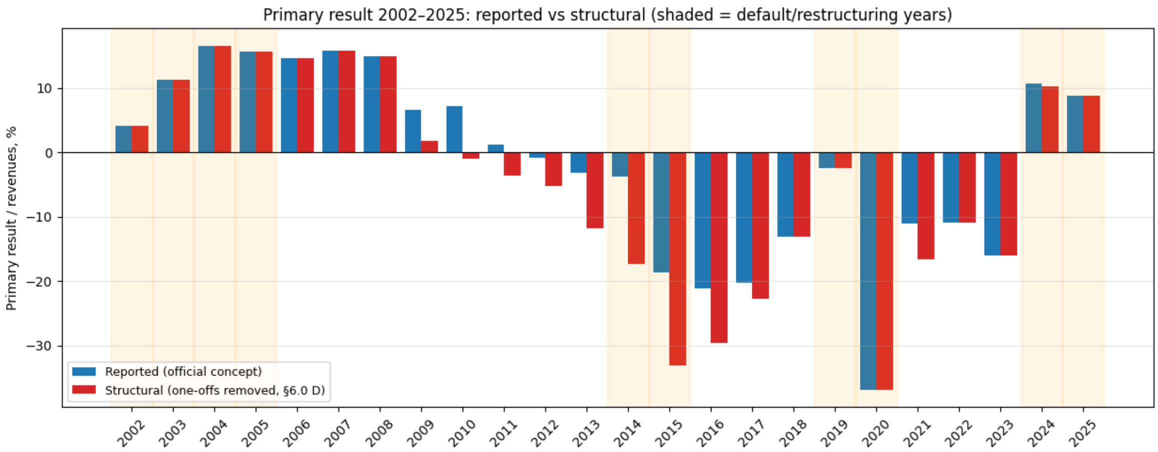

Figure 6: Official versus structural primary result: one-off and accounting-driven revenues removed.

4.6 What moves a debt ratio

Both FPI debt components are ratios of a largely hard-currency stock to a current-dollar flow, and the corrected baseline of Section 4.5 adds two measurement corrections on top of the official ratio. Five separable things therefore move the corrected debt/GDP ratio: borrowing or repayment, growth of the real denominator, revaluation of that denominator's dollar price, the closing or opening of the exchange gap, and the recognition of liabilities the official stock omits. Only the first is fiscal behaviour. Because the corrected ratio is assembled in nested steps — the observed stock B over official current-dollar GDP Y, that GDP re-valued on control years by the free/official gap κ, plus the omitted liabilities u —

the term change then splits additively and exactly in logs:

$$\Delta \ln \left(\tfrac{B}{Y}\kappa + u \right) = \underbrace{\Delta \ln B - \Delta \ln Y_{\text{real}} - \Delta \ln P^{\$}}_{\text{official ratio}} + \underbrace{\Delta \ln \kappa \; + \; \Delta \ln \left(1 + u/R_1\right)}_{\text{measurement corrections}},$$

where $R_1 = (B/Y)\kappa$. Table 2 reports the split for every administration since 1984, measured from each term's inherited year to its last — the same baseline the innovation machinery uses. The table's "cepo" column is $\Delta \ln \kappa$.

The exercise is diagnostic, not a correction: the ranking in Section 5 is unchanged by it. But it identifies which high fiscal scores rest on deleveraging and which rest on a denominator or on the corrections, and it is the motivation for the constant-price variant of Section 7. The reading is blunt. No modern administration delivers a large reduction in the *observed* debt stock: the most favourable is 2004–07, which holds it roughly flat (−1.4 log points, USD 179bn to USD 177bn), and every term since 2016 has raised it. What separates the terms is which denominator or correction moved. The largest dollar-price effects belong to Convertibility (1989–95, ninety-seven log points) and to 2003–07 (forty-eight); the largest exchange-gap effects in Table 2 are the 2020–23 widening (+61.0 log points) and its 2024–25 reversal (−63.7). Read against the observed stock, the recent improvement in the debt ratio is a valuation and consolidation event rather than repayment — a point Section 6 returns to.

Table 3: Additive decomposition of each modern term's *corrected* debt/GDP change, inherited year to last year, into log contributions that sum to the total (percent; negative is an improvement). "Stock" is the observed gross public debt in current dollars and is the only column reflecting borrowing or repayment; "cepo" is the whole-stock exchange-gap correction and "unrecog." is the remaining liability correction. Both move the ratio with no lending or repayment and are identically zero before 2001, so the pre-2000 rows reduce to the classical three-way split. Debt/exports carries no exchange-gap term because exports are already a hard-currency flow.

Administration	Span	D/Y in	D/Y out	D/Y Δ	stock	real GDP	US$ price	cepo	unrecog.
Alfonsin	1983→1989	0.522	1.039	68.9	38.4	3.7	26.9	0.0	0.0
Menem	1989→1995	1.039	0.361	-105.7	15.7	-24.6	-96.9	0.0	0.0
Menem II	1995→1999	0.361	0.431	17.7	27.1	-13.5	4.1	0.0	0.0
De la Rua	1999→2001	0.431	0.537	22.0	16.6	5.3	0.1	0.0	-0.0
Duhalde	2001→2003	0.537	1.43	98.0	21.8	3.1	71.4	0.0	1.7
N.Kirchner	2003→2007	1.43	0.742	-65.5	-1.4	-33.5	-47.8	0.0	17.1
C.Kirchner	2007→2011	0.742	0.43	-54.6	10.9	-13.4	-47.8	0.0	-4.3
C.Kirchner II	2011→2015	0.43	0.653	41.8	19.9	-1.5	-10.0	34.0	-0.6
Macri	2015→2019	0.653	0.847	26.0	29.4	4.0	24.4	-24.6	-7.3
Fernandez	2019→2023	0.847	1.375	48.4	13.7	-3.5	-33.7	61.0	10.9
Milei	2023→2025	1.375	0.723	-64.3	20.5	-2.9	-2.1	-63.7	-16.1

5 Results

5.1 The CMPI ranking

The CMPI ranking of all 41 administrations is reported in Table 3. Menem (1990–95) ranks first, the 2024–25 stabilization second, and Obligado (1854–56) third; the bottom of the table collects the crisis terms — Alsina (1853) last, preceded by Guido (1962–63), De Alvear (1923–28), the second Cristina Kirchner term (2012–15), and the hyperinflation endgame of Alfonsín (1984–89).

Table 4: The Classical Macroeconomic Pressure Index, all 41 administrations, 1853–2025. Component columns are mean innovation percentiles over the term; the pool is 173 annual observations.

Administration	Rank	Years	Regime	Inflation	Devaluation	Interest	Growth	CMPI
Menem	1	1990–1995	Modern	0.975	0.980	0.876	0.812	0.911
Milei	2	2024–2025	Modern	0.514	0.928	0.986	0.595	0.756
Obligado	3	1854–1856	Historical	0.784	0.778	0.526	0.915	0.751
Menem II	4	1996–1999	Modern	0.679	0.610	0.938	0.676	0.726
Perón II	5	1952–1955	Historical	0.880	0.871	0.552	0.436	0.685
Justo	6	1932–1937	Historical	0.345	0.831	0.731	0.805	0.678
Sarmiento	7	1869–1874	Historical	0.433	0.549	0.939	0.663	0.646
Roca	8	1881–1886	Historical	0.917	0.310	0.766	0.504	0.624
Mitre	9	1860–1868	Historical	0.404	0.435	0.809	0.665	0.579
Ramírez/Farrell	10	1943–1945	Historical	0.549	0.607	0.613	0.472	0.560
Peron III	11	1973–1975	Modern	0.530	0.303	0.844	0.516	0.548
Pellegrini	12	1891–1892	Historical	0.595	0.688	0.367	0.520	0.543
Ongania	13	1967–1969	Modern	0.686	0.663	0.121	0.699	0.542
Yrigoyen	14	1917–1922	Historical	0.682	0.490	0.315	0.680	0.542
Avellaneda	15	1875–1880	Historical	0.403	0.506	0.280	0.954	0.536
Ortiz/Castillo	16	1938–1942	Historical	0.688	0.295	0.908	0.250	0.535
Videla/Viola/Galtieri/Bignone	17	1976–1983	Modern	0.577	0.871	0.153	0.502	0.526
Sáenz Peña R./de la Plaza	18	1911–1916	Historical	0.617	0.579	0.645	0.243	0.521
N.Kirchner	19	2004–2007	Modern	0.578	0.178	0.701	0.465	0.480
Quintana/Figueroa	20	1905–1910	Historical	0.441	0.544	0.679	0.224	0.472
Aramburu	21	1956–1957	Historical	0.263	0.864	0.384	0.329	0.460
De la Rua	22	2000–2001	Modern	0.428	0.549	0.251	0.500	0.432
Fernandez	22	2020–2023	Modern	0.431	0.623	0.114	0.561	0.432
Perón I	24	1946–1951	Historical	0.323	0.213	0.465	0.719	0.430
Roca II	25	1899–1904	Historical	0.473	0.329	0.500	0.400	0.425
Juárez Celman	26	1887–1890	Historical	0.387	0.341	0.234	0.689	0.413
Yrigoyen II	27	1929–1930	Historical	0.633	0.358	0.396	0.228	0.404
Uriburu JF	28	1931–1931	Historical	0.480	0.341	0.439	0.353	0.403
Frondizi	29	1958–1961	Historical	0.416	0.403	0.350	0.442	0.403
Illia	30	1964–1966	Modern	0.499	0.133	0.254	0.713	0.400
Macri	31	2016–2019	Modern	0.397	0.423	0.422	0.316	0.390
Duhalde	32	2002–2003	Modern	0.116	0.410	0.416	0.523	0.366
Alsina II	33	1857–1859	Historical	0.547	0.620	0.214	0.067	0.362
Sáenz Peña L./Uriburu JE	34	1893–1898	Historical	0.143	0.382	0.587	0.296	0.352
Levingston/Lanusse	35	1970–1972	Modern	0.187	0.108	0.705	0.197	0.299
C.Kirchner	36	2008–2011	Modern	0.334	0.412	0.126	0.286	0.289
Alfonsin	37	1984–1989	Modern	0.399	0.448	0.014	0.274	0.284
C.Kirchner II	38	2012–2015	Modern	0.451	0.146	0.305	0.228	0.283
De Alvear	39	1923–1928	Historical	0.281	0.357	0.090	0.378	0.276
Guido	40	1962–1963	Historical	0.243	0.390	0.188	0.075	0.224
Alsina	41	1853–1853	Historical	0.104	0.145	0.416	0.000	0.166

5.2 Fiscal pressure

Table 4 reports the FPI. Obligado (1854–56) leads, with the 2024–25 term second, Roca II (1899–1904) third (0.775) and N. Kirchner (2004–07) fourth (0.719). The two debt-stock corrections of Section 4.5 drive the modern reordering: the 2023 inherited baseline carries both a free/official exchange factor of 2.021 (Table 1 reports the 2020–23 term mean of 1.857) and a central-bank quasi-fiscal debt stock of approximately eleven percent of GDP over the

2020–23 term (BCRA statistical API; Table 1), against which the 2024–25 consolidation and the measured primary surplus register as a sharp *reduction* in fiscal pressure, where the uncorrected Treasury ratio — which divides by a GDP still converted at the official rate — records an increase. The reduction is a denominator and a consolidation rather than repayment: the observed stock rose over the term (Table 2), and what the corrections change is the denominator it is measured against and the liabilities the 2023 baseline left out. The 2012–15 term falls to the bottom of the FPI, mainly because of the exchange gap (+34.0 log points in Table 2); its BCRA mean was 4.6 percent of GDP, below the 2016–19 mean of 7.2 percent, and unrecognized liabilities slightly reduced the ratio (−0.6 log points). The 2020–23 term sits next to it: it combined a quasi-fiscal stock (a term mean of 11.4 percent of GDP) with a 61.0-log-point exchange-gap widening. Néstor Kirchner (2004–07) still ranks fourth on the FPI because the 2005 restructuring — among the deepest haircuts in the modern sovereign-debt record (Sturzenegger and Zettelmeyer 2008) — cut the far larger Treasury debt even as sterilization began. That is a fall in the *ratio*, and it is worth being precise about its sources, because the FPI reads it as fiscal behaviour. Table 2 decomposes every modern term's debt-ratio change into the observed stock, the real denominator, the denominator's dollar price, and the two corrections. For 2003–07 the observed stock was essentially flat — USD 179bn to USD 177bn, −1.4 log points — while corrected debt/GDP fell 65.5. The improvement is 33.5 points of real growth and 47.8 of dollar-price revaluation, against which the recognition of holdout and quasi-fiscal liabilities pushes back 17.1. Almost none of it is repayment: the 2005 haircut removed debt that the reported stock had already ceased to accrue, and what the term did not do was retire the surviving stock. The same reading applies, with different weights, to Convertibility (1989–95): a stock that grew 15.7 log points against a ratio that fell 105.7. Section 7 re-ranks the FPI with the revaluation removed.

Table 5: The Fiscal Pressure Index, all 41 administrations. Components are innovation percentiles of debt/GDP, debt/exports, primary result/revenues, primary result/debt service, and $(1+r)/(1+g)$ over the common 173-year pool; the six missing 1861–63 primary-result ratios are arithmetic interpolations of the observed 1860 and 1864 endpoints, not source measurements.

Administration	Rank	Years	Debt / GDP	Debt / Exp	Res / Rev	Res / DebtSv	(1+r) / (1+g)	FPI
Obligado	1	1854–1856	0.701	0.690	0.967	0.933	0.942	0.847
Milei	2	2024–2025	0.951	0.827	0.731	0.815	0.821	0.829
Roca II	3	1899–1904	0.719	0.898	0.962	0.876	0.418	0.775
N.Kirchner	4	2004–2007	0.945	0.892	0.487	0.652	0.621	0.719
Menem	5	1990–1995	0.969	0.565	0.617	0.572	0.851	0.715
Perón I	6	1946–1951	0.798	0.970	0.734	0.318	0.692	0.702
Avellaneda	7	1875–1880	0.821	0.550	0.512	0.478	0.963	0.665
Mitre	8	1860–1868	0.326	0.389	0.905	0.969	0.699	0.658
Yrigoyen	9	1917–1922	0.601	0.768	0.624	0.579	0.623	0.639
Uriburu JF	10	1931–1931	0.636	0.775	0.746	0.647	0.341	0.629
Ongania	11	1967–1969	0.480	0.410	0.651	0.827	0.565	0.587
Videla/Viola/Galtieri/Bignone	12	1976–1983	0.417	0.229	0.879	0.861	0.402	0.558
Sarmiento	13	1869–1874	0.268	0.405	0.553	0.678	0.707	0.522
Illia	14	1964–1966	0.491	0.486	0.435	0.435	0.645	0.499
Macri	15	2016–2019	0.435	0.285	0.620	0.850	0.299	0.498
Menem II	16	1996–1999	0.399	0.627	0.354	0.331	0.751	0.492
De la Rua	17	2000–2001	0.303	0.942	0.364	0.445	0.364	0.484
Frondizi	18	1958–1961	0.678	0.597	0.434	0.308	0.399	0.483
Aramburu	19	1956–1957	0.598	0.572	0.448	0.416	0.327	0.472

Administration	Rank	Years	Debt / GDP	Debt / Exp	Res / Rev	Res / DebtSv	(1+r) / (1+g)	FPI
Sáenz Peña L./Uriburu JE	20	1893–1898	0.803	0.527	0.348	0.332	0.350	0.472
Quintana/Figueroa	21	1905–1910	0.804	0.801	0.159	0.237	0.315	0.463
C.Kirchner	22	2008–2011	0.821	0.736	0.227	0.202	0.215	0.440
De Alvear	23	1923–1928	0.307	0.500	0.555	0.555	0.267	0.437
Pellegrini	24	1891–1892	0.127	0.428	0.540	0.616	0.465	0.435
Levingston/Lanusse	25	1970–1972	0.426	0.655	0.331	0.441	0.306	0.432
Perón II	26	1952–1955	0.382	0.149	0.412	0.663	0.474	0.416
Justo	27	1932–1937	0.256	0.097	0.456	0.439	0.829	0.415
Sáenz Peña R./de la Plaza	28	1911–1916	0.287	0.546	0.400	0.456	0.304	0.399
Alfonsin	29	1984–1989	0.289	0.185	0.843	0.611	0.055	0.397
Peron III	30	1973–1975	0.449	0.636	0.073	0.143	0.588	0.378
Roca	31	1881–1886	0.552	0.364	0.138	0.218	0.562	0.367
Ramírez/Farrell	32	1943–1945	0.362	0.582	0.121	0.183	0.518	0.353
Duhalde	33	2002–2003	0.003	0.179	0.486	0.590	0.503	0.352
Ortiz/Castillo	34	1938–1942	0.612	0.109	0.281	0.306	0.430	0.348
Yrigoyen II	35	1929–1930	0.633	0.350	0.205	0.263	0.246	0.339
Guido	36	1962–1963	0.434	0.893	0.142	0.118	0.092	0.336
Juárez Celman	37	1887–1890	0.121	0.205	0.316	0.288	0.623	0.311
Alsina II	38	1857–1859	0.216	0.518	0.195	0.162	0.073	0.233
Fernandez	39	2020–2023	0.027	0.262	0.192	0.107	0.357	0.189
C.Kirchner II	40	2012–2015	0.117	0.218	0.237	0.150	0.221	0.189
Alsina	41	1853–1853	0.017	0.104	0.000	0.017	0.000	0.028

5.3 The Overall Index

Table 5 combines the two indices. Menem (1990–95) remains first, Obligado second, and the 2024–25 term third, followed by Mitre (1860–68) and the second Menem term. Two terms reach the top ten almost entirely through the fiscal index: N. Kirchner (2004–07), eighth on a CMPI rank of nineteen (Overall 0.600, tied at displayed precision with Avellaneda and Roca II), and Roca II (1899–1904), seventh on a CMPI rank of twenty-five — the pattern discussed below. At the foot of the table sit Alsina (1853), the second Cristina Kirchner term (2012–15) and Guido (1962–63). The joint reading exposes the central *passing-the-buck* dynamic: administrations with a high CMPI rank paired with a low FPI rank bought macroeconomic calm with debt — on the Treasury's books or hidden in the central bank — and handed the bill to their successors. The 2024–25 term is unusual in the modern era for ranking in the top tier on both dimensions, with the caveats of Sections 6 and 8: the presidency continues through 2027. Two measurement conventions work in favour of its currently observed 2024–25 record, but they are not parallel to the Kirchner-era CPI correction: capitalized interest enters the headline debt-service ratio, while the 2004–05-basket CPI understatement is a sensitivity variant that costs the term one CMPI place (Section 7). Complete annual observations are used for 2025, but recent national-account values remain subject to source revisions.

Table 6: The Overall Index. The headline rank is the mean of the CMPI and FPI *scores* (Menem first), the original study's convention.

Administration	Rank	Years	CMPI Rank	FPI Rank	CMPI	FPI	Overall
Menem	1	1990–1995	1	5	0.911	0.715	0.813
Obligado	2	1854–1856	3	1	0.751	0.847	0.799

Administration	Rank	Years	CMPI Rank	FPI Rank	CMPI	FPI	Overall
Milei	3	2024–2025	2	2	0.756	0.829	0.792
Mitre	4	1860–1868	9	8	0.579	0.658	0.618
Menem II	5	1996–1999	4	16	0.726	0.492	0.609
Avellaneda	6	1875–1880	15	7	0.536	0.665	0.600
Roca II	7	1899–1904	25	3	0.425	0.775	0.600
N.Kirchner	8	2004–2007	19	4	0.480	0.719	0.600
Yrigoyen	9	1917–1922	14	9	0.542	0.639	0.591
Sarmiento	10	1869–1874	7	13	0.646	0.522	0.584
Perón I	11	1946–1951	24	6	0.430	0.702	0.566
Ongania	12	1967–1969	13	11	0.542	0.587	0.564
Perón II	13	1952–1955	5	26	0.685	0.416	0.550
Justo	14	1932–1937	6	27	0.678	0.415	0.547
Videla/Viola/Galtieri/Bignone	15	1976–1983	17	12	0.526	0.558	0.542
Uriburu JF	16	1931–1931	28	10	0.403	0.629	0.516
Roca	17	1881–1886	8	31	0.624	0.367	0.495
Pellegrini	18	1891–1892	12	24	0.543	0.435	0.489
Quintana/Figueroa	19	1905–1910	20	21	0.472	0.463	0.468
Aramburu	20	1956–1957	21	19	0.460	0.472	0.466
Peron III	21	1973–1975	11	30	0.548	0.378	0.463
Sáenz Peña R./de la Plaza	22	1911–1916	18	28	0.521	0.399	0.460
De la Rua	23	2000–2001	22	17	0.432	0.484	0.458
Ramírez/Farrell	24	1943–1945	10	32	0.560	0.353	0.457
Illia	25	1964–1966	30	14	0.400	0.499	0.449
Macri	26	2016–2019	31	15	0.390	0.498	0.444
Frondizi	27	1958–1961	29	18	0.403	0.483	0.443
Ortiz/Castillo	28	1938–1942	16	34	0.535	0.348	0.441
Sáenz Peña L./Uriburu JE	29	1893–1898	34	20	0.352	0.472	0.412
Yrigoyen II	30	1929–1930	27	35	0.404	0.339	0.372
Levingston/Lanusse	31	1970–1972	35	25	0.299	0.432	0.366
C.Kirchner	32	2008–2011	36	22	0.289	0.440	0.365
Juárez Celman	33	1887–1890	26	37	0.413	0.311	0.362
Duhalde	34	2002–2003	32	33	0.366	0.352	0.359
De Alvear	35	1923–1928	39	23	0.276	0.437	0.357
Alfonsin	36	1984–1989	37	29	0.284	0.397	0.340
Fernandez	37	2020–2023	22	39	0.432	0.189	0.311
Alsina II	38	1857–1859	33	38	0.362	0.233	0.297
Guido	39	1962–1963	40	36	0.224	0.336	0.280
C.Kirchner II	40	2012–2015	38	40	0.283	0.189	0.236
Alsina	41	1853–1853	41	41	0.166	0.028	0.097

6 Validation against the original study

The implementation is validated against two benchmarks.

Replication of the published rankings. Restricting the percentile pool to 1853–1999 removes the pool-expansion effect, so any deviation from the original Table 3.4 reflects the known data differences (flat within-term interest averages and WDI-sourced inflation and growth for 1964–99), plus the disclosed choice to interpolate the six missing 1861–63 raw ratios before ranking rather than complete relative-index scores after ranking. On this restricted pool the FPI reproduces the original fiscal ranking with Spearman $\rho = 0.996$ and the CMPI with $\rho = 0.953$. The devaluation convention is validated term by term: the December-quotation series reproduces the original published Table 3.2 devaluation innovations exactly for three of the four administrations affected by mid-year devaluations (Illia +27.1,pp, Onganía –9.0,pp, Perón III +60.4,pp) and within 0.1,pp for the 1976–83 junta (–81.3 vs. the original –81.4), where annual-average data produce the wrong sign.

Decomposition of the observed 2024–25 record. Table 6 decomposes the two complete Milei calendar years against the first two Menem years. The structure is the corrective-shock one: a first year dominated by the devaluation and interest components against a hyper-distressed inherited baseline, and a second year in which the disinflation component takes over. The comparison bounds the interpretation of the interim presidency ranking: on a first-two-years basis (Section 7) the 2024–25 program ranks immediately behind the Menem stabilization, in the same order as the full-term CMPI. These are descriptive ranks rather than formal statistical tests, but the equal-window comparison does show that the currently observed record's standing is not an artefact of comparing two years with longer administration windows.

Table 7: Year-by-year CMPI decomposition: the complete 2024 and 2025 observations versus the first two years of the Menem stabilization.

Year	Administration	Inflation	Devaluation	Interest	Growth	CMPI
2024	Milei	0.081	0.931	0.977	0.503	0.623
2025	Milei	0.948	0.925	0.994	0.688	0.889
1990	Menem (first 2 yrs)	0.936	0.965	0.876	0.665	0.861
1991	Menem (first 2 yrs)	0.971	0.971	0.876	0.913	0.933

7 Robustness

Sensitivity and attribution variants. The headline FPI uses the corrected fiscal baseline: documented holdout debt, official 2024–25 capitalized interest, measured one-off-revenue removal, paired importer-debt increases/BOPREAL residuals, cepo revaluation, and BCRA quasi-fiscal debt. Cumulative importer-debt increases in 2022–23 and audited Series 1–3 BOPREAL residuals in 2024–25 are paired inside this headline; isolating the pair moves no focus FPI rank. Models excluded for insufficient annual evidence have no numerical variants. The re-ranked variants in Table 7 report the paper-comparable official convention, the conservative 50 percent lower bound, and the total-growth $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$ definition. A 1946–59 parallel-premium overlay remains a notebook-only sensitivity; Obligado holds the top of the FPI under that overlay as well as under every Table 7 column. The largest movement is the 2024–25 term's fall from second to tenth under the original-study convention, which is the comparator's purpose: it is what the term scores when the corrections of Section 4.5 are withheld and the raw Treasury series is taken at face value. The remaining FX variant shows how the whole-stock headline changes if only half the stock is treated as foreign-currency exposure. Macri moves from fifteenth to twentieth at 50 percent; Fernández and the second Cristina Kirchner term swap the bottom two places. Every other focus administration keeps its headline rank.

Table 8: FPI rank sensitivity for the focus administrations under the exchange-control and growth-definition variants.

Administration	Corrected baseline	Original-study convention	50% FX share	Total-growth r/g
Obligado	1	1	1	1

Administration	Corrected baseline	Original-study convention	50% FX share	Total-growth r/g
Milei	2	10	2	2
Roca II	3	2	3	3
N.Kirchner	4	3	4	4
Menem	5	4	5	5
Macri	15	29	20	15
C.Kirchner II	40	39	39	39
Fernandez	39	38	40	40
Duhalde	33	32	33	33

Inflation sources. The headline is the continuous official Santa Fe IPEC chain. Its lower and upper sensitivity bounds use official CABA and San Luis observations only where those retained files overlap, rather than a cross-source private-index average. The basket-vintage variant of Appendix B row 17 shifts the annual-average series by the gap between the IPCBA and the national index over 2017–2024; because the stale 2004–05 basket under-weights services, the gap raises measured inflation in 2024 from 218 to 245 percent. It costs the 2024–25 term one place, from second to third, and the 2020–23 term two, from twenty-second to twenty-fourth; no other focus administration moves. CABA and San Luis are sensitivity columns only; Santa Fe remains the headline. The basket-vintage variant is likewise outside the headline because it rests on a single-jurisdiction index.

Component weights. The equal weighting of components is the original study's convention; the component-exclusion variants bound its impact as extreme weight perturbations. Menem remains first with the interest dimension removed entirely, while the 2024–25 term falls from second to fifth — the country-risk collapse is a material part of its score — and Obligado falls from third to fifth when inflation, its coarsest pre-1866 proxy dimension, is removed.

Term length. Re-scoring every administration on its first two years only (Table 8) gives every administration the same two-year observation window. The CMPI podium is unchanged — Menem, the 2024–25 term, then Obligado — but Macri rises from thirty-first to twelfth, so the equal window moves more than the short-corrective-shock caveat alone.

Table 9: Full-term versus first-two-years CMPI ranks, selected administrations.

Administration	Full-term rank	First-2-years rank
Menem	1	1
Milei	2	2
Obligado	3	3
Menem II	4	4
Justo	6	5
Perón II	5	6
Roca	8	7
Peron III	11	8
Sarmiento	7	9
Ramírez/Farrell	10	10
Sáenz Peña R./de la Plaza	18	11
Macri	31	12

Component collinearity. Equal weighting also treats the components as independent, which they are not: over the 173-year pool inflation and devaluation co-move at a Pearson correlation of 0.88, so the CMPI effectively places about half its weight on a single nominal-instability factor, while within the FPI the two primary-result ratios correlate at 0.82 and the two debt ratios at 0.52 (Table 9). The component-exclusion variants of Section 7 are the correlation-aware bound on this. Menem holds the CMPI lead in every one of them, but the second and third places do not survive: the 2024–25 term falls to fifth when the interest dimension is dropped and Obligado to fifth when inflation is, so the bound is on the leader rather than on the podium.

Table 10: Within-index component collinearity — Pearson correlation of the annual innovations over the 173-year pool.

Component pair	Pearson r
Inflation – Devaluation (CMPI)	0.88
Primary result/Rev – /DebtServ (FPI)	0.84
Debt/GDP – Debt/Exports (FPI)	0.51
Debt/GDP – (1+r)/(1+g) (FPI)	0.30

Reverting the interest restorations. The two restorations of Section 4.4 are in the corrected baseline, so the variants that test them run in reverse. Table 10 removes the default-window substitution: leaving four default years at their market quotation gave the 2004–07 term the second-best interest innovation of the 173-year pool and an inherited $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$ of 1.453 rather than 1.105. No modeled cash-interest alternative is retained; the strict provenance rule admits only series with official annual operands.

Table 11: CMPI, FPI and Overall ranks with the payments-default substitution reverted (column (a)). Both indices are re-ranked because $(1+r)/(1+g)$ is built from the same series. The substitution is symmetric: the 2002–03 term, charged the cost of the collapse, moves with it.

Administration	CMPI base	CMPI (a)	FPI base	FPI (a)	Overall base	Overall (a)
Menem	1	1	5	5	1	1
Milei	2	2	2	2	3	3
Obligado	3	3	1	1	2	2
Mitre	9	9	8	8	4	5
N.Kirchner	19	11	4	4	8	4
Roca II	25	25	3	3	7	8
De la Rua	22	23	17	17	23	23
Duhalde	32	39	33	37	34	39
C.Kirchner	36	35	22	22	32	31
Macri	31	31	15	15	26	27
Fernandez	22	22	39	40	37	36

The denominator effect. Table 2 showed that the modern debt ratios move for five separable reasons, only one of which is borrowing or repayment. This variant removes the revaluation by rescaling each modern year's debt ratios by the dollar price index of its own denominator (2003 = 1.000), optionally with the part of the 2005 exchange that is a transfer from creditors rather than fiscal effort — the face reduction on the tendered claims, which the holdout add-back does not cover — and the GDP warrants issued with the exchange and paid by successors.

Unlike the interest restorations this one is **not** promoted, and the obstacle is coverage rather than principle. The constant-price aggregates begin in 1960 and the terms-of-trade index in

1980. A full-sample substitute is constructible from series already in the study — the dollar price of domestic output moves with the difference between the inflation and devaluation log-rates, both of which exist from 1853 — but it fails validation against the measured World Bank deflator over 1960–2024: annual log-changes correlate at 0.52, the mean absolute annual gap is 0.21 log points, and the 1989–95 cumulative comes out at 6.83 against a measured 2.63. The failures are structural. Hyperinflation breaks the December-quotation/annual-average timing identity, and on exchange-control years the proxy would double-count the revaluation already applied in Section 4.3, because this study prices those years at the free-market rate while World Bank GDP uses the official one. Before 1960 no validation is possible at all, since the historical debt ratios arrive from the original workbook already divided. There is also a reason of principle to stop: debt/exports is immune to this channel, both sides being in dollars, so a promoted correction would reach one of the two debt ratios over a third of the pool.

Table 11 stacks everything, and it is worth being exact about what survives. The *membership* of the top three is invariant: 1990–95, 1854–56 and 2024–25 occupy the first three places in all seven specifications. Their *order* is not. Menem leads under the four interest specifications; among the three denominator columns Obligado leads two and the 2024–25 term leads the constant-price specification. Each of the three therefore spans more than one place (Menem one to three, Obligado one to two, the 2024–25 term one to three). Below the podium the denominator variants move terms a good deal further: the 2004–07 term spans Overall ranks four to eighteen of forty-one — four under the pre-revision interest convention, eighteen once the 2005 face reduction is added back — and the 2008–11, 2002–03 and 1999–2001 terms span six, ten and four places respectively (Overall 31–36, 30–39 and 23–26). The robust claim is therefore about which three administrations lead, not about their sequence, and not about the placement of the terms whose scores rest on the 2001–05 default cycle.

Table 12: Overall rank under each variant and under the stacked variants. The first columns revert the interest restorations that are in the baseline; the rest add the denominator variants that are not. The administrations whose scores rest on the 2001–05 default cycle move furthest; the top three keep their places as a group, though they reorder within it.

Administration	Baseline	Bare spread	No subst.	Pre-revision	Const-price	+ add-backs	Stacked
Menem	1	1	1	1	3	3	3
Obligado	2	2	2	2	2	1	1
Milei	3	3	3	3	1	2	2
Mitre	4	4	5	5	4	5	5
N.Kirchner	8	8	4	4	11	18	15
Roca II	7	7	8	8	7	7	7
Duhalde	34	34	39	39	30	30	39
De la Rua	23	23	23	23	26	26	27
C.Kirchner	32	35	31	34	36	36	36
Macri	26	26	27	27	24	24	24
Fernandez	37	37	36	36	38	38	38

8 Discussion

The 173-year unified ranking reproduces the main findings of the original study for the historical period while placing the 2000–2025 administrations on the same scale. Stabilizations anchored to hard-currency or convertible regimes score highest — Menem's Convertibility first in both the original and here; Obligado's 1854–56 reforms, which ended decades of inflationary finance, near the top — and crisis terms score lowest. The 2024–25 disinflation scores highly even in this long-run context.

Four interpretive points deserve emphasis.

What the index measures. The CMPI rewards improvement relative to the inherited year, averaged over the term — not the state in which an administration leaves the country. The clearest modern case is the Fernández (2020–23) versus Macri (2016–19) inversion: Macri had lower absolute inflation, devaluation, and country risk, yet ranks just below Fernández, because Macri inherited the calm, exchange-control-pinned 2015 economy and bequeathed the 2019 crisis against which Fernández is then scored each year (for an insider account of the 2016–19 program and its collapse, see Sturzenegger 2019). COVID amplifies the inversion through the V-shaped 2020–21 pair. This is an artefact of the single-year inherited baseline — a design feature, disclosed and bounded in Section 7 — and the ranking should be read alongside the contemporaneous record (Appendix C).

Why the data corrections are decisive. Five adjustments determine the credibility of the modern ranking: the alternative price indices stop the 2007–2015 manipulation from inflating the affected scores; the restored interest *level* — country-risk spread plus the risk-free leg, with the 2002–05 payments-default window held at its last functioning-market quotation — keeps the dimension in the original's concept across 173 years and removes four readings that were not borrowing costs; the December-quotation devaluation series fixes the wrong-signed innovations around mid-year devaluations; the two debt-stock corrections keep the fiscal components from mismeasuring the 2003–2025 terms in both directions; and the decomposition of Table 2 separates the part of a debt-ratio improvement that is repayment from the parts that are a denominator or a correction.

The default cycle is a measurement boundary, not only an episode. The 2001–05 default supplies the inherited baseline for two consecutive terms, and it distorts both indices at once, because the interest series that scores country risk in the CMPI also builds the FPI's $(1+r)/(1+g)$. Left as a bare quotation, four default years generated innovations three and a half times larger than anything else in the pool and handed the term that exited the default the second-highest interest component of the forty-one terms, while charging the term that entered it with the mirror image. On the Overall Index the default-window substitution is directionally symmetric but not equal in size: the 2002–03 term rises five places (39 to 34) and the 2004–07 term falls two (4 to 6). Those two — and only those two — move by more than one Overall place in Table 10; stacking both interest restorations also moves the 2008–11 term from 32 to 34. What survives the correction is instructive. The 2004–07 term still ranks fourth on the FPI — but Table 2 shows that its corrected debt ratio fell 65.5 log points while the observed stock in current dollars barely moved, so the improvement is a write-off and a denominator rather than repayment. That is the *passing-the-buck* dynamic operating inside the measurement itself: a revaluation credited to the administration that governs the upswing and charged to the one that governs its reversal.

The passing-the-buck reading. Administrations that pair a high CMPI with a low FPI purchased calm with future resources. The quasi-fiscal channel is the modern refinement of the original thesis: where the nineteenth-century version of the dynamic ran through Treasury debt and suspension of convertibility, the twenty-first-century version runs through the central bank's balance sheet — invisible in the official debt statistics that the original authors could take at face value for their period.

Why the buck keeps being passed. The index documents the pattern; it does not by itself explain its persistence over 173 years, and nothing in a percentile rank identifies the constraints a given administration faced. The political-economy literature supplies the candidate mechanism: Spiller and Tommasi (2007) show that Argentine institutions — short and uncertain tenures, a federal fiscal commons, weak legislative and judicial enforcement of intertemporal bargains — systematically shorten policymakers' horizons, making debt, visible or hidden, the cheapest instrument with which to buy the present. Read through Buera and Nicolini (2021), the FPI is the administration-level trace of the fiscal dominance that the comparative Latin American literature identifies at the level of regimes (Kehoe and Nicolini 2021). These are interpretations consistent with the ranking, not findings of it.

9 Limitations

The principal limitations, each documented in the replication package and bounded by a sensitivity variant where feasible:

- **Historical interest rates (1852–1997) use published term averages**, so historical administrations have flat within-term interest variation; with WDI-sourced 1964–99 inflation and growth, this is the main remaining source of divergence from the original ranking ($\rho = 0.953$).
- **Inflation is normally an annual-average blend, with a documented 2007–2015 exception.** Half the regular modern series is a wholesale-price index and, before 2017, the consumer leg is an output deflator; both legs are annual averages while devaluation and the official Santa Fe correction use December-to-December rates. The regular convention systematically penalises the first year of a fast disinflation and rewards the first year of a fast acceleration, because the average lags the turning point. Its largest single effect in this sample is on 2024, whose innovation changes sign between the two conventions. No variant re-ranks on the December basis, for the coverage reason given in Section 4.2.
- **Data-regime seam at 1963/64** for inflation and growth; devaluation has no seam. The interest dimension switches source in 1998, from the original's flat within-term real-rate averages to the annual EMBIG series, but no longer switches *concept*: adding the US ten-year real yield back to the spread restores the rate level and closes the seam to +0.13 percentage points, against −3.77 for the bare spread (Section 4.4). The Section 7 variants revert the restoration, and the Overall podium is unchanged either way.
- **The interest dimension carries two curated restorations.** The 1998–2002 US real yields are estimates rather than measured constant-maturity yields (the measured series begins in 2003); the held 2002–05 window assigns four years a level nobody observed, which is honest about the absence of a market price but is still an assumption; and the 2019–20 restructuring is left at its quotation on the judgement that the exchange was consensual and its coupons capitalized. Both restorations are reverted in Section 7.
- **One input drives two of the nine components.** The post-1998 interest series is both the CMPI interest dimension and the FPI's $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$, so any remaining distortion in it is counted twice in the Overall Index.
- **The FPI debt ratios respond to their denominator and to this study's own corrections, not only to borrowing.** Real appreciation or a terms-of-trade upswing improves both ratios with the debt stock unchanged, and the reversal is charged to the successor — the pathology this study is named after, operating inside its own measurement. The exchange-gap correction of Section 4.5 behaves the same way and

dominates the recent record: Table 2's cepo column supplies 61.0 log points of the 2020–23 ratio increase and 63.7 of the 2024–25 decrease, in both cases against an observed debt stock that rose. Table 2 decomposes every modern term and Section 7 re-ranks with the revaluation removed; it is not promoted to the baseline because no constant-price denominator exists before 1960.

- **Four mechanisms are disclosed but not scored without reproducible annual operands**: the 2009 amnesty, the 2022–23 export-duty timing effect, unpaid default interest in 2002–05, and a year-by-year Paris Club accrual path. Price controls and frozen tariffs likewise remain documented without a series that separates their effect from observed inflation.
- **The FPI's $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$ uses per-capita growth** (the only annual series available across the full span) where the original defines g as total growth; innovations difference out slow-moving population growth almost entirely, and the total-growth variant moves every focus rank by at most one position (Table 7).
- **The exchange-control revaluation applies the free/official factor to the whole published USD Treasury stock.** The 50-percent variant is the remaining conservative exposure bound. Central-bank remunerated liabilities are added unscaled.
- **The quasi-fiscal consolidation uses measured December year-end stocks** from the central bank's statistical API for 2002–2025 (the 2025 stock is measured and economically negligible after the Treasury migration). Curated anchors remain as cross-checks. The 1977–90 historical stock is documented but not re-ranked.
- **The corrected FPI baseline is a corrected baseline, not the official fiscal convention**: the original-study-convention columns keep the reported stock and cash-result measures for audit, while the headline uses the corrected columns that consolidate the documented modern accounting distortions.
- **A debt-definition seam at 1999/2000**: the 1853–1999 ratios arrive from the original workbook on its central-government concept, while every modern year is total Sector Público Nacional gross debt read from the same Secretaría de Finanzas A.2.5 series. The seam is therefore at the regime boundary rather than inside the modern block, and the modern block is internally consistent throughout.
- **Pool non-comparability**: adding eight modern terms changes every historical percentile; the full-pool ranking is an extension, not a reproduction, of the original 33-term table. The single 173-year pool is nonetheless deliberate: one common yardstick is what allows a Confederation presidency and a twenty-first-century stabilization to be ranked at all. Era-specific sub-pools would re-score every administration against its own era's standards — undoing the cross-era comparability the index exists to provide — while introducing arbitrary regime break points; standardized (z-score) scoring was rejected because hyperinflation-era tails would dominate any variance-based scale. Percentile ranks over one pool are the design that survives both objections.
- **The single-last-year inherited baseline is likewise a convention.** Averaging several pre-term years would dilute one-off shocks in the inherited year, but it would also smear the predecessor's own crisis into the benchmark a government is judged against, weakening the question the index asks. The V-shaped-shock caveat of Section 3.4 discloses the principal consequence.
- **Equal component weights are the original study's convention**; the component-exclusion variants of Section 7 act as extreme weight perturbations and bound the impact of this choice on the focus ranks.
- **The indices measure macroeconomic and fiscal management only.** Distributional outcomes, poverty, productivity, and institutional quality are outside the nine variables; an administration can rank highly here while performing poorly on those

dimensions, and conversely. The ranking is one input to an overall assessment of a government, not a verdict.

- **Two 2024–25 measurement caveats work in the current administration's favour**, but they are not parallel to the Kirchner-era CPI correction: official capitalized-interest operands adjust the headline debt-service ratio, while the 2004–05-basket CPI understates the services-led relative-price normalization only in a sensitivity variant that costs the term one CMPI place (Section 7).

10 Conclusion

Applying both indices of della Paolera, Irigoin, and Bózzoli (2003) across the full 1853–2025 span places all 41 Argentine national administrations on a single 173-year percentile pool, subject to the cross-era differences in source concepts and correction coverage set out in Section 4. The method's logic — judging each government by the macroeconomic and fiscal improvement it delivers over the situation it inherited — puts durable hard-currency and convertible stabilizations at the top and crises, and the terms that bequeath them, at the bottom. The unified ranking reproduces the original historical results almost exactly on the restricted pool while extending them through 2025 with corrected data: the continuous official Santa Fe IPEC chain for the 2007–2015 statistical manipulation, with official CABA and San Luis sensitivities; an interest dimension restored to the original's real hard-currency *rate level* and held at its last functioning-market quotation through the 2002–05 payments default, free-market exchange rates for the control years, December-quotation devaluations throughout, and — for the fiscal dimension — an exchange-control revaluation and the consolidation of the central bank's quasi-fiscal debt.

Two results of this exercise are worth separating. The first is the ranking itself, which is consistent with the original *passing-the-buck* thesis over the long run: administrations that purchased macroeconomic calm with debt — on the Treasury or hidden in the central bank — handed the bill to their successors. Making the hidden half of that debt visible is, we would argue, the precondition for internally comparable measurement of Argentine economic governance.

The second is that the same dynamic operates inside the measurement, and has to be corrected for before the ranking can be read. A sovereign default distorts both indices simultaneously, because the price of defaulted paper is not a borrowing cost and yet enters the country-risk dimension of one index and the debt-amplification factor of the other. A real-exchange-rate or terms-of-trade cycle improves a debt ratio with the debt stock unchanged, so the improvement is credited to whoever governs the upswing and the reversal charged to whoever governs its end. Both effects concentrate on the two administrations that straddle the 2001–05 crisis. On the Overall Index the default-window substitution moves those two by five and two places in opposite directions (Table 10); it does not, by itself, move any other administration by more than one place, and it leaves the podium and the replication of the original ranking intact. Stacking both interest restorations also moves the 2008–11 term by two Overall places. An index built to detect governments that pass costs forward has to be audited for the same behaviour in its own inputs; where the audit could be settled on the original's own concept it was promoted to the baseline, and where it could not be extended to the full 1853–2025 pool it was left as a reported bound.

Reproducibility

Appendix A. The replication package — notebook, data, and paper-generation scripts — is at https://github.com/jahnog/still-passing-the-buck, with archived snapshots at Zenodo and MPRA. Every table and figure is extracted from the executed notebook.

Data and code availability. All code, redistributable source data, processed datasets, validators, and paper-generation scripts are in the public replication package.

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The statistical-integrity catalogue

Appendix B. The full twenty-three-entry catalogue, with per-row sources, is maintained in the replication package; the condensed version follows. "Corrected" practices are fixed in the baseline (official series kept as audit columns); "Sensitivity" practices enter re-ranked variants only; "Documented" practices are flagged for the reader. The machine-readable taxonomy in `data/provided/correction-taxonomy.csv` is the controlling source for whether a practice affects the corrected headline, the paper-comparable audit columns, or sensitivity variants only.

Table 13: The statistical-integrity catalogue (condensed). Full entries with affected terms, magnitudes, and per-row sources are in the replication package.

#	Practice	Period	Bias	Treatment
1	INDEC CPI manipulation (official Santa Fe chain replaces the fake CPI)	2007–15	Inflation down	Corrected
2	GDP volume manipulation, base-1993 accounts	2007–15	Growth up	Corrected
3	GDP warrants (cupón PBI): issued 2005, paid by successors	2005–14	Debt down for the issuer	Sensitivity
4	Exchange controls (cepo), official rate pinned	2012–15, 2019–25	Devaluation, debt/GDP down	Corrected
5	Historical exchange controls and parallel premia	1931–59	Devaluation down	Sensitivity
6	Cash-basis fiscal reporting during debt suspension	2002–05	Potential result/debt-service bias	Documented only
7	Holdout debt excluded from official stock	2005–15	Debt down	Corrected
8	CER stealth haircut via fake CPI	2007–15	Debt, interest down	Documented
9	Measured FGS property income following pension nationalization	2009–15	Result/revenue up	Corrected where an official operand is retained
10	Reserve hollowing; measured booked BCRA transfers	official-report years	Result/revenue up	Corrected where an official operand is retained
11	Hidden central-bank debt stock (Lebac/Leliq/Pases)	2002–2025 (peak 13.4% of GDP in 2023; run off to near zero by 2024)	Debt down	Corrected

#	Practice	Period	Bias	Treatment
12	Hidden central-bank deficit (quasi-fiscal flow)	2004–24	Result up	Documented
13	1980s Cuenta de Regulación Monetaria	1984–89	Debt down, result up	Sensitivity
14	Measured one-off revenues (official FGS/BCRA, 2016–17/2024 regularization, 2021 SDR)	official-operand years	Result/revenue up	Corrected
15	Importer-debt increase / BOPREAL residual pairing	2022–25	Debt down, then up	Corrected
16	Cash surplus excluding capitalizing interest	2024–25	Result up	Corrected
17	CPI basket vintage (2004–05 weights)	2017–25	Inflation down	Sensitivity
18	Price controls; repressed inflation to successor	several	Incumbent inflation down	Documented
19	Statistics blackouts and labour-data masking	2002–16	Non-index inputs affected	Documented
20	Crisis balance-sheet transfers (1982, 1989, 2002)	as listed	Debt up (real)	Documented
21	Mechanisms lacking reproducible official annual operands	several	Potential fiscal bias	Documented only
22	Default premium and missing risk-free leg in the interest series	1998–2025 seam; 2002–05 window	Interest improvement up for the term exiting default	Corrected
23	Debt-ratio denominator revaluation (real FX, terms of trade)	1960–2025	Debt ratios down	Sensitivity

The contemporaneous record

Appendix C. For the reader who wants the absolute outcomes alongside the innovation-based ranking, the table below reports term-average inflation, devaluation, interest, and growth for all 41 administrations.

Table 14: Contemporaneous (absolute) term averages, all 41 administrations. Mitre's two primary-result ratios include the three arithmetically interpolated 1861–63 cells, so every column averages the same nine term years. This is the record against which the caveat of Section 3.4 should be read.

Administration	From	To	Inflation	Devaluation	Interest	Growth
Alsina	1853	1853	14.11	14.11	15.19	-17.53
Obligado	1854	1856	3.19	3.19	14.10	7.15
Alsina II	1857	1859	0.53	0.53	15.72	-4.82
Mitre	1860	1868	1.68	2.08	12.70	7.43
Sarmiento	1869	1874	4.33	0.00	8.63	2.30
Avellaneda	1875	1880	10.01	2.24	10.02	5.19
Roca	1881	1886	-2.94	3.25	7.22	8.08
Juárez Celman	1887	1890	12.06	15.46	8.79	5.40
Pellegrini	1891	1892	10.86	12.15	9.72	-4.43
Sáenz Peña L./Uriburu JE	1893	1898	-1.23	-4.12	8.22	0.72
Roca II	1899	1904	-1.72	-1.76	7.32	3.82
Quintana/Figueroa	1905	1910	4.97	0.04	5.50	2.43
Sáenz Peña R./de la Plaza	1911	1916	3.71	0.06	3.73	-3.99
Yrigoyen	1917	1922	1.03	2.70	5.08	3.10
De Alvear	1923	1928	0.09	-2.72	8.63	2.94
Yrigoyen II	1929	1930	-3.67	7.47	8.77	-2.45
Uriburu JF	1931	1931	-3.31	23.26	8.72	-9.22

Administration	From	To	Inflation	Devaluation	Interest	Growth
Justo	1932	1937	3.98	-0.62	6.02	1.88
Ortiz/Castillo	1938	1942	4.52	4.55	2.09	0.77
Ramírez/Farrell	1943	1945	5.57	-1.46	0.52	0.77
Perón I	1946	1951	20.93	31.58	-0.02	2.72
Perón II	1952	1955	10.25	7.19	-1.25	0.89
Aramburu	1956	1957	20.93	1.64	-0.49	2.21
Frondizi	1958	1961	34.67	20.15	0.46	2.31
Guido	1962	1963	26.05	24.42	2.89	-2.41
Illia	1964	1966	21.68	22.50	4.39	5.02
Ongania	1967	1969	13.35	9.24	7.64	4.29
Levingston/Lanusse	1970	1972	31.16	40.28	5.48	1.83
Peron III	1973	1975	58.84	79.67	2.44	1.12
Videla/Viola/Galtieri/Bignone	1976	1983	107.37	94.51	5.15	-0.28
Alfonsin	1984	1989	173.14	181.46	17.38	-2.04
Menem	1990	1995	65.75	33.73	14.26	2.86
Menem II	1996	1999	-0.94	0.00	10.15	2.29
De la Rua	2000	2001	0.69	0.00	15.02	-3.68
Duhalde	2002	2003	27.51	54.27	19.07	-2.06
N.Kirchner	2004	2007	11.06	1.47	12.34	7.64
C.Kirchner	2008	2011	18.89	7.80	9.86	2.49
C.Kirchner II	2012	2015	21.67	30.43	8.70	-0.62
Macri	2016	2019	30.64	40.93	7.37	-1.80
Fernandez	2020	2023	54.12	64.00	20.69	0.87
Milei	2024	2025	72.38	22.90	12.54	1.17

Index construction: exact formulas

Appendix D. This appendix states the complete scoring algebra; it matches the implementation in the replication package (`scripts/cmpi_core.py`) line for line.

Terms and innovations. Let administration j govern years $f_j, \dots, l_j$, and let $x_{v,t}$ denote the value of variable v in year t. Inflation and devaluation enter as continuously compounded rates, $x = \ln(1 + \pi)$. Every year of the term is scored against the same inherited benchmark — the last year of the predecessor:

$$\Delta_{v,t} = x_{v,t} - x_{v,\,f_j-1}, \qquad t = f_j, \dots, l_j.$$

Percentile assignment. Innovations are pooled across the 173-year 1853–2025 frame. Let O_v be the number of observed innovations for variable v: $O_v = 173$ except for the two primary-result components, where $O_v = 170$. For each variable, the observed innovation in position o of the favourable-to-unfavourable ordering (best = 1) receives the percentile score of the original Appendix A:

$$R_{v,t} = \frac{O_v - o_{v,t}}{O_v} \in \left[0,\ \tfrac{O_v-1}{O_v}\right].$$

Favourable means *lower* for inflation, devaluation, the real interest rate, and the three FPI debt and amplification variables, and *higher* for growth and the two FPI primary-result variables.

Ties. Exactly equal innovations share the average of the percentile slots they span: if k observations tie at positions $o, \dots, o+k-1$, each is scored at $\bar{o} = o+(k-1)/2$ rather than at its own position, so identical values always receive identical scores. This is not a corner case. Because the 1852–1997 interest series is built from published *term averages*, that column takes only 57 distinct values over the 173-year pool and 86 percent of its observations fall in a tied group; resolving those ties in sort order would leave the headline ranking dependent on a non-stable sort. The devaluation column has 8 percent of its observations tied; inflation and growth have none. The same principle governs the rank labels every table reports: administrations whose index scores are exactly equal share a position and the next position is skipped. One pair is affected on the CMPI (De la Rúa and Fernández at twenty-second) and none on the FPI.

Historical fiscal completion. For primary result/revenues and primary result/debt service, the workbook has no observations in $\mathcal{M} = \{1861, 1862, 1863\}$. Those six raw ratios are completed before ranking by arithmetic interpolation between the observed endpoints:

$$x_{v,t} = x_{v,1860} + \frac{t-1860}{4}\left(x_{v,1864} - x_{v,1860}\right), \qquad t \in \mathcal{M}.$$

Geometric interpolation is undefined because Result/Revenue changes sign. Every FPI component then ranks $O_v = 173$ innovations, including the three constructed years. This complete-pool convention differs from the original Appendix A procedure, which ranked the available observations first and interpolated only the resulting relative-index scores. The three filled years remain reconstructed observations, not measurements.

Aggregation. An administration's component score is the mean relative score over its term years, and each index is the unweighted mean of its components ($n = 4$ for the CMPI, $n = 5$ for the FPI):

$$\mathrm{CMPI}_j = \frac{1}{4}\sum_{v\in\mathcal{C}} \frac{1}{T_j}\sum_{t=f_j}^{l_j} R_{v,t}, \qquad \mathrm{FPI}_j = \frac{1}{5}\sum_{v\in\mathcal{F}} \frac{1}{T_j}\sum_{t=f_j}^{l_j} R_{v,t},$$

with $\mathcal{C} = \{$inflation, devaluation, interest, per-capita growth$\}$ and $\mathcal{F} = \{$debt/GDP, debt/exports, primary result/revenues, primary result/debt service, $(1+r)/(1+g)\}$. The Overall Index is $\frac{1}{2}(\mathrm{CMPI}_j + \mathrm{FPI}_j)$.

Debt dynamics. The FPI components derive from the first-order difference equation for the debt ratio,

$$\frac{B_t}{Y_t} = \frac{1+r_t}{1+g_t}\frac{B_{t-1}}{Y_{t-1}} + \frac{DEF_t}{Y_t},$$

whose amplification factor $(1+r_t)/(1+g_t)$ enters the FPI directly.

The modern debt-stock corrections. Write $R_t^{\mathrm{off}} = B_t/Y_t$ for the official ratio, $\kappa_t = e_t^{\mathrm{parallel}}/e_t^{\mathrm{official}}$ for the exchange-gap factor (identically one outside control years), and Q_t for the central bank's remunerated liabilities. During exchange-control years the official rate overstates dollar GDP, so the published USD stock is revalued against parallel-rate GDP and the quasi-fiscal stock is consolidated unscaled:

$$R_t^{\mathrm{adj}} = R_t^{\mathrm{off}}\kappa_t + \frac{Q_t}{Y_t}.$$

The corrected column used for the headline FPI adds two further liabilities that the official stock omits — untendered holdout debt and the paired importer-debt-increase/BOPREAL-residual operand — each entering only inside its documented window and never with a negative sign:

Let D_t^k be the dollar value of add-back k and Y_t^p be GDP converted at the parallel rate because those add-backs are dollar liabilities:

$$\left(\frac{B}{Y}\right)_t^{\text{corr}} = R_t^{\text{adj}} + \sum_{k\in\{h,\,a\}} \max\left\{0,\ \frac{D_t^k}{Y_t^p}\right\}.$$

The debt/exports ratio takes the same add-backs but no κ, exports already being a hard-currency flow:

$$\left(\frac{B}{X}\right)_t^{\text{corr}} = \frac{B_t}{X_t} + \frac{Q_t + \sum_k D_t^k}{X_t}.$$

The paired operand is generated from two retained BCRA artifacts rather than hand-entered estimates. For 2022 and 2023 it is the increase in the RAyPE year-end stock of imported-goods plus imported-services debt relative to the common December-2021 baseline (USD 9,975.821m and USD 28,219.351m). For 2024 and 2025 it is the audited residual value of BOPREAL Series 1–3 in Note 4.15 of the 2025 financial statements (USD 9,147.038m and USD 6,817.813m); the mixed-purpose Series 4 is excluded. These are distinct accounting objects. Their pairing is an attribution convention, not a claim that the private importer debt was already public debt; isolating the pair moves no focus FPI rank.

Section 4.6 decomposes a term's change in $(B/Y)^{\text{corr}}$ into the five additive log contributions implied by this identity.

Measured primary-result corrections. Where retained official one-off revenues are a share o of dataset-379 total revenues, the headline structural ratio is

$$\left(\frac{\text{Result}}{\text{Rev}}\right)^{\text{structural}} = \frac{R-o}{1-o}.$$

The same adjusted primary-result numerator enters the debt-service component. If D is the reported Result/DebtService ratio, then

$$\left(\frac{\text{Result}}{\text{Debt service}}\right)^{\text{structural}} = D\,\frac{R-o}{R}.$$

For 2024–25 only, let p_t be dataset-379 cash interest and c_t the capitalized-interest peso operand reported by OPC, each divided by nominal GDP. The headline debt-service ratio is

$$\left(\frac{\text{Result}}{\text{Debt service}}\right)_t^{\text{corr}} = \left(\frac{\text{Result}}{\text{Debt service}}\right)_t^{\text{structural}} \times \frac{p_t}{p_t + c_t}.$$

No capitalized-interest adjustment is applied outside 2024–25.

Glossary

Appendix E. Terms used throughout the paper, in alphabetical order.

Administration (term) The unit of analysis: one of the 41 government intervals of 1853–2025 (Section 3.5). Each year of a term is scored against the last year of the predecessor.

Brecha (parallel premium) The percentage gap between the free-market and the official exchange rate during exchange-control years; it reached 100 percent in the modern cepos.

CCL / blue The two free-market dollar quotations used for the control years: the *contado con liquidación* rate (implicit in dual-listed securities) and the informal cash ("blue") rate.

Cepo Colloquial name for Argentina's exchange-control regimes (2012–15 and 2019–25), under which the official rate was administratively pinned below the free-market rate.

CMPI Classical Macroeconomic Pressure Index: the average innovation percentile across inflation, devaluation, the hard-currency real interest rate, and per-capita growth (Section 3.1).

Convertibility The 1991–2001 currency-board regime pegging the peso one-to-one to the US dollar.

December quotations The exchange-rate convention used throughout: year-end (December) rates rather than annual averages, which blend pre- and post-devaluation months and produce wrong-signed innovations (Section 4.3).

FPI Fiscal Pressure Index: the average innovation percentile across debt/GDP, debt/exports, primary result/revenues, primary result/debt service, and the debt-amplification factor $(1 + r)/(1 + g)$ (Section 3.2).

INDEC manipulation The 2007–2015 falsification of the official consumer-price index — a fake CPI — and the parallel volume manipulation of real growth. Commerce Secretary Guillermo Moreno was criminally convicted (upheld on appeal); the IMF issued the first declaration of censure in its history. Corrected in the baseline with the continuous official Santa Fe IPEC chain, with official CABA and San Luis overlap as sensitivity evidence (Section 4.3).

Innovation The annual value of a variable minus its value in the last year of the previous administration — the inherited condition (Section 3.1).

Overall Index The simple average of an administration's CMPI and FPI scores.

Percentile pool The single pool of 173 annual observations (1853–2025) over which each variable's innovations are ranked; the innovation in position o scores $(O - o)/O$.

Primary result The fiscal balance before interest payments; "structural" variants remove one-off revenues booked above the line.

Quasi-fiscal debt The central bank's remunerated liabilities (Lebac/Nobac, Leliq/Notaliq, Pases) — economically public debt but absent from Treasury statistics; consolidated into the debt stock for 2002–2025 (Section 4.5).

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